

Redmi Buds 4 Active

A pleasant surprise!

Amongst the thousands of TWS earbuds we have on offer in the ₹1,000 to ₹2,000 bracket, we have a new kid trying to make its way in. It is the Redmi Buds 4 Active. These TWS earbuds from the house of one of the most popular brands in India, Xiaomi, are trying to give their competitors from brands like Realme, Oppo, boAt, and the like a run for their money.

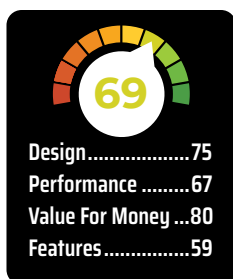
So, when the Redmi Buds 4 Active showed up at the Digit Test Centre (before launch), I started testing them, I made sure to draw parallels between these earbuds and similarly priced devices. I put these earbuds through our testing process, and here's what I found out –

BUILD AND DESIGN

As soon as you pull the Redmi Buds 4 Active earbuds out of the box, they scream simplicity. The case (on the outside) and the buds have a monotone design, which I love. When you open the case, you get a slight touch of dark grey inner cavity housing the earbuds, which is a nice touch. There's a subtle glossy strip running along the circumference of the case, which is also something that adds to the overall appeal of the buds.

The case and the buds both have a matte finish, apart from that glossy strip that I mentioned. There's no loud branding on the case apart from the back.

The case hinge is plastic and, much to my disappointment, isn't as clicky and robust as I would like it to be. But, if you are into doing "cool stuff", then you can hold the case, flick it, and the lid would open. I tried it several times to make sure that the buds didn't go flying out of the



cavity, and they didn't, which gave me enough confidence to mention this trick here. But, again, keep in mind the hinge is slightly on the loose side out of the box and is made with plastic, so reserve the trick for special occasions ;-)

As for the fit and comfort of the buds themselves, they are lightweight and comfortable to wear for long periods of time. Even when you are going for a run or to the gym, stay assured that these earbuds will stay in place should not be an issue. They are also rated IPX4, so they should be fine against light sweat and splashes of water and sweat.

As for the materials used, both the case and the earbuds are made of the same material, which during my time of use, resisted scratches and scuffs pretty well. There were minor scratches on the glossy part of the case, but overall the case and the buds held their own.

FEATURES

Like some of the earbuds that I have reviewed recently, the Redmi Buds 4

Active come with a limited yet robust feature set. There's not much on offer with these earbuds, but whatever is baked in is solid for the most part. Why didn't I end the sentence at solid? Well, you'll know.

Let's start with the good part first. It is the pairing. The process of getting these earbuds into pairing mode is easy. Not that intuitive, as you have to take these earbuds out of the case, put them on and then tap thrice on each of the two stems. But, once it is in pairing mode, the process is robust. Even fast pairing with compatible devices works like a charm. I have had experiences with pricier earbuds with Google Fast Pair implementation.

As stated earlier, these earbuds are IPX4 rated, so they are protected against light sweat and splashes of water. Pair that with their great fit, and you have a budget-friendly workout companion.

These earbuds also have ENC for listening, which works some software magic to identify any anomalous sounds in your environment and negates them. For the price that these earbuds are retailing at, this is a very welcome addition. When you pair it with the right fitting eartips, which you have three sizes to choose from, you can get surprising results.

Now, coming to the part which I have the biggest gripe, the controls. The controls of these earbuds is one area where I expected Xiaomi to put in much more effort and refine them. Right now, it is a hit-and-miss when you are changing tracks. The responsiveness is something that I expect the brand to work on when they release the next pair or a firmware update to make whatever we have with these earbuds better. There is no volume control on the earbuds either, which, again, strips one point off. I know that it is not that common at this price, but a bump of about ₹500 with better controls and the addition of a couple of more features would have been nice to have for sure! Right now, it would be a dealbreaker for me, at least.